

Channels Onboarding — RC&D Leadership Cohort

Audience: Research Computing & Data senior and associate directors **Environment:** Preprod (<https://chat-preprod.dartmouth.edu>) **Format:** Live guided walkthrough, ~20 minutes **Facilitator:** Simon

Pre-Session Admin Setup (before the meeting)

- ☒ Ensure `ENABLE_CHANNELS=True` in preprod config
 - ☒ Create or verify a user group for the 4 RC&D leadership members
 - ☒ Grant `features.channels` permission to that group
 - ☒ Pre-create one standard channel: **#rcd-leadership** with read/write access for the RC&D group
 - ☒ Post a welcome message in **#rcd-leadership** so it is not empty when participants arrive
 - ☒ Verify at least one AI model is available for @mention (e.g., GPT-4o, Claude Sonnet)
 - ☒ Confirm all 4 participants can log into preprod
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Session Flow (20 minutes)

Part 1 — Orient (3 min)

Goal: Participants understand what Channels is and where to find it.

Talking points:

- Channels adds Slack-like real-time messaging directly inside Dartmouth Chat
- It lives in the **left sidebar** under the "Channels" section
- Three types of channels exist:
 - **Standard channels** (#) — visible to permitted users, created by admins
 - **Group channels** (🔒) — invite-only, anyone can create
 - **Direct messages** — 1-on-1 conversations
- Everything stays within Dartmouth Chat — same login, same data policies

Do together:

1. Open preprod and locate the **Channels** section in the sidebar
 2. Click into **#rcd-leadership** — note the channel header, member count, and pin icon
 3. **Enable browser notifications** — so they do not miss messages during the pilot:
 - Profile icon (bottom-left) → Settings → General → toggle **Notifications** to On → Allow browser permission
 - Optionally: Settings → Interface → toggle **Always Play Notification Sound**
 - Note: there are no per-channel notification controls; this is a global toggle
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Part 2 — Communicate (5 min)

Goal: Participants send messages, reply in threads, and react.

Do together:

1. **Post a message** in #rcd-leadership — just say hello
2. **Reply in a thread** — click the reply icon on someone else's message and respond
3. **React to a message** — hover over a message, click the emoji icon, pick a reaction
4. **Pin a message** — hover over the welcome message, click the  menu, select Pin

Point out:

- Unread counts appear as badges on channels in the sidebar
- Threads keep side conversations organized without cluttering the main channel
- Pinned messages are accessible via the  icon in the channel header

Part 3 — Mention an AI Model (5 min)

Goal: Participants see how AI models participate directly in channel conversations.

Do together:

1. Type @ in the message input — note the suggestion list shows **users**, **models**, and **channels**
2. Select an AI model (e.g., @gpt-4o or @claude-sonnet)
3. Ask it a question right in the channel — e.g., "*@gpt-4o Summarize the key challenges of research data management in 3 bullet points*"
4. Watch the AI respond inline in the channel — visible to everyone

Point out:

- The AI only sees the **thread** it is mentioned in — not the rest of the channel. A top-level @mention means the model sees just that one message. Inside a thread, it sees up to 50 thread messages.
- You can also reply to a previous AI response to continue the conversation — no need to @mention again.

Discussion prompt:

- How could AI-in-channel be useful for your team? (brainstorming, drafting, quick research questions)

Part 4 — Create Your Own (5 min)

Goal: Participants create a group channel and a DM on their own.

Do together:

1. Click the + button next to "Channels" in the sidebar
2. Select **Group Channel** as the type
3. Name it something fun (e.g., test-pilots, rc-sandbox)
4. **Invite at least one other participant** as a member
5. Post a message in the new group channel

Then on your own:

1. Create a **Direct Message** with another participant

2. Send them a message — note the online/offline status indicator

Point out:

- Group channels are invite-only — non-members cannot see or access them
- You can manage members from the channel header (click the people icon)
- Only admins can create standard (public) channels; you can create group channels and DMs freely

Part 5 — Wrap Up and Feedback (2 min)

Goal: Set expectations for the pilot period and collect first impressions.

Talking points:

- This is the start of a 2-week pilot — please use channels naturally with your team
- **#rcd-leadership** is your home base — use it for real discussions, questions, AI experiments
- Things to notice and report back on:
 - Is the channel vs. chat distinction clear?
 - Are AI @mentions useful in a group context?
 - What is missing? (e.g., notifications, search, archiving)
 - Any confusing UX moments?

Ask:

- Pin a thread in #rcd-leadership titled "Feedback & Friction" where anyone can post observations during the pilot
- We will check in at the end of week 1 and do a final debrief at the end of week 2

Quick Reference Card

Action	How
Find channels	Left sidebar → Channels section
Post a message	Click into a channel, type in the input box, press Enter
Reply in a thread	Click the reply icon on any message
React to a message	Hover → emoji icon → pick reaction
Pin a message	Hover → ... menu → Pin
View pinned messages	Channel header → 📌 icon
@mention a person	Type @ → select from user list
@mention an AI model	Type @ → select from model list
@mention a channel	Type # → select from channel list
Create a group channel	Sidebar → Channels + button → Group Channel
Create a DM	Sidebar → Channels + button → Direct Message

Action	How
Manage members	Channel header → people icon
Upload a file	Drag and drop into the message input, or click the attachment icon

Known Limitations to Communicate

Limitation	What to tell participants
AI context scope	The AI model only sees the thread it is mentioned in — not the rest of the channel. A top-level @mention means the model sees just that message. Inside a thread, it sees up to 50 messages.
No message edit history	Edited messages do not show previous versions.
No channel archiving	Channels can be deleted but not archived. Do not delete channels during the pilot.
Standard channel creation	Only admins can create public standard channels. Participants can create group channels and DMs.
Credit usage	AI responses in channels consume credits the same as regular chats.